

CENTRAL ASIAN CONTACTS

INDO-GREEKS • SHAKAS • PAHLAVAS • KUSHANAS

CORE FIRST • SOURCE-QUALIFIED • ONE CONTINUOUS EXAM RAIL

1/13

BOUNDARY, ROUTES AND NON-LINEAR CHRONOLOGY

c. 200 BCE–300 CE: a connected frontier world, not one invasion wave.

Bactria/Oxus → Hindu Kush → Kabul–Gandhara–Taxila → Punjab–Mathura → Ganga routes.

Lower Indus and western ports linked caravan traffic to Iran, the Roman world and Indian Ocean.

Indo-Greek, Shaka, Pahlava and Kushana powers overlapped with Shunga, Kanva and Satavahana states.

WRITE: group → ruler/source → region → mechanism → impact → limit.

ANSWER LINE: WRITE: group → ruler/source → region → mechanism → impact → limit.

2/13

SOURCE LADDER AND CONFIDENCE CONTROL

1

COINS: names, portraits, titles, scripts, deities, metals, dies and overstrikes.

3

ARCHAEOLOGY/ART: sites, workshops, routes, monasteries and material context.

5

BUDDHIST/LATER TRADITIONS: Menander and Kanishka memories; genre and redaction limits.

2

INSCRIPTIONS: dates/eras, donors, officials, genealogy and royal claims.

4

CHINESE/CLASSICAL TEXTS: Yuezhi movement, Bactria and trade; translated outsider categories.

6

CORE CAUTION: coin circulation ≠ political border; style ≠ ethnicity; praise ≠ neutral report.

ANSWER LINE: CORE CAUTION: coin circulation ≠ political border; style ≠ ethnicity; praise ≠ neutral report.

3/13

INDO-GREEKS: DYNASTIES, COINS AND MENANDER

1

Demetrius: early 2nd-century BCE crossing south of Hindu Kush; route and extent debated.

3

Bilingual portrait coins: Greek/Prakrit legends, Greek/Kharoshthi scripts, epithets and monograms.

5

Milindapanha: layered dialogue with Nagasena, not a verbatim court record or proof of mass conversion.

2

Several houses and rulers were concurrent; no secure continuous Bactria-to-Pataliputra empire.

4

Menander/Milinda: coin-secure ruler associated with Sagala; wide circulation is not a frontier.

6

Heliodorus: Antialcidas' envoy, Bhagavata, Garuda/Vasudeva pillar at Besnagar; one person's affiliation.

ANSWER LINE: Heliodorus: Antialcidas' envoy, Bhagavata, Garuda/Vasudeva pillar at Besnagar; one person's affiliation.

4/13

SHAKAS AND WESTERN KSHATRAPAS

Maues/Moga and Azes: north-western coin-inscription sequences; Azes-era association disputed.

Rajuvula: Mathura Kshatrapa; early 1st-century CE capture of Sagala from Strato III.

Kshatrapa/Mahakshatrapa: flexible ranks; delegated rule could become dynastic sovereignty.

Nahapana/Kshaharata: coins and Ushavadata donations; Gautamiputra overstrikes mark displacement.

Chashtana–Rudradaman/Kardamaka: durable western line; cross-link, do not absorb into Satavahana history.

Junagadh, Shaka year 72: Sudarshana repair + genealogy + conquest + Sanskrit prashasti; rhetoric remains.

ANSWER LINE: Junagadh, Shaka year 72: Sudarshana repair + genealogy + conquest + Sanskrit prashasti; rhetoric remains.

5/13

PAHLAVAS / INDO-PARTHIANS

01

Gondophares/Guduhvara anchors a distinct Indo-Parthian layer in Afghanistan–Gandhara.

02

Coins and the dated Takht-i-Bahi context are firmer than later narrative traditions.

03

Inherited Greek titles and coin forms show adaptation, not dynastic identity with Indo-Greeks.

04

The Acts of Thomas association has historical interest but cannot authenticate every itinerary or event.

05

Do not erase Pahlavas as an empty bridge between Shakas and Kushanas.

ANSWER LINE: Do not erase Pahlavas as an empty bridge between Shakas and Kushanas.

6/13

YUEZHI MOVEMENT AND KUSHANA RULER SEQUENCE

Chinese histories: Yuezhi displaced west, dominate Bactria; Guishuang/Kushana branch consolidates.

Kujula Kadphises: early unification and south-Hindu-Kush expansion; chronology remains approximate.

Vima Takto / Soter Megas: identification historically debated; Rabatak reshaped genealogy.

Vima Kadphises: major gold/copper issues and Shiva/Oesho-associated imagery.

Kanishka I: major modern chronology c. 127 CE; do not automatically equate with Shaka era 78 CE.

Huvishka and Vasudeva I: later high-Kushana phases; names and icons do not prove exclusive creed.

ANSWER LINE: Huvishka and Vasudeva I: later high-Kushana phases; names and icons do not prove exclusive creed.

7/13

MULTI-CENTRED EMPIRE AND TITLES

01

Major centres: Bactria, Kapisa/Begram, Purushapura, Taxila and Mathura.

02

Rabatak names eastern cities, but royal claims require corroboration for depth of control.

03

Direct rule, subordinate authority, influence and coin circulation must be mapped separately.

04

shaonano shao = king of kings; devaputra = son of god; exalted sovereignty across idioms.

05

Satrapas, local rulers, cities, guilds and religious establishments mediated governance.

06

No single capital or uniform district system fits every reign and region.

ANSWER LINE: No single capital or uniform district system fits every reign and region.

8/13

TRADE, CUSTOMS, CITIES AND MONETISATION

01

Silk Routes were changing corridors, not one road owned by Kanishka.

02

Kushana nodes linked China/Tarim, Bactria, Gandhara, north India, Iran and maritime circuits.

03

States taxed/protected segments; merchants, caravans, ports, guilds and monasteries made exchange work.

04

Gold and copper Kushana issues show high-value and everyday monetary capacity in selected circuits.

05

Roman contact is one bullion/trade factor, not the sole cause of Kushana gold or universal prosperity.

06

Mathura, Taxila, Purushapura and Begram were differentiated caravan, craft and consumption centres.

ANSWER LINE: Mathura, Taxila, Purushapura and Begram were differentiated caravan, craft and consumption centres.

9/13

MILITARY MOBILITY AND STIRRUP CAUTION

1

Horses, saddles, bridles, bows, armour and riding dress moved through repeated contact and adaptation.

2

Tunics, trousers and boots are contact-zone visual markers, not ethnic certificates.

3

Cavalry suited the Bactria–Gandhara–plain corridors and became prominent in royal imagery.

4

Coin/statue images show representation more securely than unit organisation or battlefield doctrine.

5

True-stirrup dating is contested: do not confuse toe loops/supports with paired iron stirrups.

6

SAFE VERDICT: stronger cavalry influence—yes; sole Kushana invention of the stirrup—unproven.

ANSWER LINE: SAFE VERDICT: stronger cavalry influence—yes; sole Kushana invention of the stirrup—unproven.

10/13

RELIGION, MAHAYANA AND PLURAL PATRONAGE

1

Kanishka: major Buddhist patron in coins, inscriptions, monuments and later memory.

2

Council in Kashmir and Sarvastivada compilation survive chiefly in later traditions; details are contested.

3

Mahayana developed gradually; no ruler single-handedly founded it.

4

Kanishka/Huvishka coins include Buddha, Oesho, Nana, Miir/Mithra, Mao, Atash and other deities.

5

Coin deity = public iconography/constituency strategy; not automatic personal conversion.

6

Transmission depended on monks, translators, merchants, monasteries and routes as well as rulers.

ANSWER LINE: Transmission depended on monks, translators, merchants, monasteries and routes as well as rulers.

11/13

GANDHARA, MATHURA AND MULTILINGUAL CULTURE

1

Gandhara: schist/stucco, modelled anatomy, wavy hair and drapery in a layered Buddhist idiom.

2

Mathura: red sandstone, older local forms, Buddhist–Jaina–Brahmanical–royal range.

3

Neither school was pure, isolated or merely a copy; Buddha-image priority remains debated.

4

Indo-Greek coins: Greek + Prakrit, Greek + Kharoshthi; Kushana usage includes Bactrian in Greek script.

5

Rudradaman's Junagadh: major courtly Sanskrit inscription; Prakrit and other languages continued.

6

Calendar, astronomy, clothing and science claims must separate selective exchange from total invention.

ANSWER LINE: Calendar, astronomy, clothing and science claims must separate selective exchange from total invention.

12/13

SOCIAL INTEGRATION, SYNTHESIS AND DECLINE

01

Integration worked through service, marriage, language, donations, guilds, cults and workshop life.

02

Brahmanical labels such as fallen kshatriya classifications are normative arguments, not census data.

03

Replace one-way Indianisation with reciprocal but unequal adaptation and cosmopolitan synthesis.

04

Indo-Greek fragmentation, regional Shaka longevity and Kushana contraction followed different clocks.

05

Kushana decline: dynastic division + Sasanian pressure + regional successors + changing fiscal/routes.

06

Political rupture coexisted with continued coins, art, Buddhist transmission and regional institutions.

ANSWER LINE: Political rupture coexisted with continued coins, art, Buddhist transmission and regional institutions.

13/13

UPSC TRAPS, PYQ ROUTE AND QUALIFIED VERDICT

01

2019 GS-I: separate Greco-Bactrian visual form from Central Asian patronage, costume and route context.

02

Prelims traps: ruler–dynasty, title–office, coin–border, deity–conversion, era–accession, script–language.

03

10 marks: 2–3 evidence units; 15 marks: 4–6; 20 marks: 6–8 plus source criticism.

04

PARAGRAPH: claim → named coin/inscription/site/text/ruler → analysis → qualification.

05

VERDICT: contacts produced frontier states, monetised networks and plural cultures without uniform control.

06

Never attribute every innovation solely to invasion or every adaptation to passive assimilation.

ANSWER LINE: Never attribute every innovation solely to invasion or every adaptation to passive assimilation.

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

10

11

12

13